



Daystar University
MAY- AUGUST 2026 Trimester
Theology of Work and Development
THEO 401A
Date: Monday, June 22, 2026

Week 5: Introduction to the Historical Context of Faith and Development

Lesson Objectives

1. Understand the evolution of faith's role in development.
2. Recognize key historical periods influencing faith-based social change.
3. Analyze the contributions and critiques of faith-based initiatives throughout history.
4. Reflect on contemporary implications of faith and development.

Early Roots of Faith and Development

- Religious groups have long contributed to social welfare.
- Examples:
 - Christian monasteries: education, healthcare.
 - Islamic waqf institutions: charitable endowments.
 - Buddhist communities: social support and compassion.
- Faith-driven charity in ancient civilizations.

Religious Traditions and Social Impact

- Christianity: Hospitals, schools, charitable organizations.
- Islam: Zakat (almsgiving), Waqf (endowments).
- Buddhism: Compassion-driven social services.
- Impact on social cohesion and community support.

Influence of Major Historical Movements

- The Enlightenment:
 1. Challenges to religious authority.

2. Rise of secular philanthropy.

- The Industrial Revolution:

1. Expansion of charitable work.
2. Growth of civil society.

- Religious reform movements: Morality and social justice.

Faith-Based Movements & Social Change**

- Abolition of slavery:

- a. Christian abolitionists (e.g., William Wilberforce).

- Civil rights:

- a. MLK Jr.'s Christian faith.

- Missionary expansion:

- a. Education, healthcare, and cultural influence.

- Faith-inspired social welfare:

- a. Salvation Army, Catholic social teaching.

Colonialism & Faith

- Missionaries accompanied colonial expansion.

- Impact:

- a. Spread of Christianity and Islam.
- b. Education and healthcare initiatives.

- Post-colonial developments:

- a. Faith-based organizations rebuilding societies.
- b. Challenges: cultural imperialism, dependency.

Contemporary Perspectives

- Rise of faith-based NGOs:

- a. World Vision, Caritas, Islamic Relief.
- Theological frameworks:
 - a. Liberation theology.
 - b. Prosperity gospel.
 - c. Eco-theology.
- Role in addressing:
 - a. Poverty, health crises, climate change.

Challenges & Critiques

- a. Proselytization vs. development goals.
- b. Cultural insensitivity.
- c. Dependency and power dynamics.
- d. Pluralism and religious tolerance.
- e. Secular vs. faith-based approaches.

Main points of Lesson

- a. Faith has played a multifaceted role in development across history.
- b. Contributions include social welfare, education, and social justice.
- c. Critical perspectives highlight challenges and potential for collaboration.
- d. Understanding history informs ethical and effective practices today.

After the lecture, divide students into four groups and assign each group one discussion question. Encourage them to identify historical examples, theological insights, and contemporary applications, then present their findings to the class.

Group After Class Discussion Questions

Group 1: Faith and Social Transformation Through History

Religious communities have played significant roles in education, healthcare, and social welfare throughout history.

Question:

How have faith traditions contributed to human development and social transformation from ancient times to the present day? Discuss specific examples from Christianity, Islam, and Buddhism, and evaluate their long-term impact on society.

Group 2: Faith, Colonialism, and Development

Missionary movements often accompanied colonial expansion, producing both positive and negative outcomes.

Question:

To what extent did missionary activities contribute to development during the colonial period, and what challenges emerged from the relationship between faith and colonialism? How should contemporary faith-based organizations respond to this historical legacy?

Group 3: Faith-Based Movements and Social Justice

Many major social reform movements have been inspired by religious convictions.

Question:

Examine the role of faith in advancing social justice movements such as the abolition of slavery, civil rights, and poverty alleviation. What lessons can contemporary development practitioners learn from these historical faith-based initiatives?

Group 4: Contemporary Challenges for Faith and Development

Faith-based organizations remain important actors in addressing poverty, health crises, and environmental challenges.

Question:

What are the major strengths and criticisms of faith-based development organizations today? Discuss issues such as proselytization, cultural sensitivity, dependency, religious pluralism, and collaboration with secular organizations. How can faith-based organizations remain effective and ethical in the twenty-first century?

Reporting Back

Each group should:

1. Summarize its discussion in **3–5 key points**.
2. Identify **one historical lesson** and **one contemporary application**.
3. Present a **practical recommendation** for faith-based development work in Africa today.

Time Allocation: 20 minutes discussion + 5 minutes presentation per group.